
THE THIRTY-EIGHTH CONGREGATION A Witness Account of the Desert Dance

The Many-Masked demands witness.

[NOTE: Title page — shattered mirror illustration with desert sand pouring through cracks. Masks and flames visible in reflected fragments. Bone-white and fevered gold palette. Typography: Title in Oswald Bold 36pt, subtitle in Crimson Text 14pt italic]

|| CLASSIFIED TESTIMONY — INTERPLANAR TRAVEL NETWORK || || Witness: Chronicler Vedris Halfmoon || || Curator Arcanum (Veiled Sight) || || Filed: 38²/₃ years after the previous incident || || Transcription: Without editorial judgment, || || as is the Path of Open Doors ||

The thing you need to understand—and I say this knowing full well that understanding will not stop you—is that we knew people were going to die.

Not *might* die. Not *could* die. *Would*. Certainly. Inevitably. In quantities that make "party casualty" feel like a category error.

We went anyway.

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It starts, as all planar crimes do, with someone who knows someone. In my case, a spirit-speaker from the northern tribes who claimed her ancestors had shown her "the way through." I should have asked *which* ancestors. The Howl doesn't give directions to safety—it simply gives directions. But she had a portal anchor, and I had forty years of studying the Curator's Paths without ever walking one that mattered.

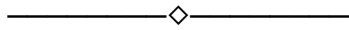
The Veiled Sight teaches us that some truths should be hidden. It does not teach us not to look first.

"Thirty-eight and two-thirds years," she said. "The Waste opens a window. Gephorig allows it."

"Allows it," I repeated.

"The Many-Masked does not *allow* anything." She smiled—too wide, too knowing. "He *invites*. For about twenty days, His realm becomes *available*. The portals open across every plane—the Weave, the Verge, the Hollow, all open to intensity. This is his sacrament. The congregation just doesn't realize they're attending his church."

I should have noticed she used his epithets without hesitation. That meant she'd already decided the return trip was optional.



[NOTE: Half-page illustration — The portal mouth against the Ashen Waste. Bone-colored sand stretching to crystalline spires on the horizon. Figures silhouetted against a sky that burns too bright. Ink line art with gold and bone wash]

The portal deposited us at dusk—or what passes for dusk in the Ashen Waste, which is simply "slightly less murderously bright."

I should explain the Waste for those who have never felt it.

Gephorix's realm is not merely a desert. It is *sensation distilled*—a place where every nerve ending remembers what it means to feel. The heat doesn't just burn; it *caresses* as it burns, making you uncertain whether to scream or sigh. The air tastes of copper and jasmine and something older, something that makes your pulse quicken against your will. Those who worship the Many-Masked speak of this place as paradise. Those who have visited know the truth: it is paradise *and* perdition, experienced simultaneously, until you cannot remember which one you came seeking.

The sand was the color of dried bone, and it moved wrong. Not wind-shifted. *Curious*. Like it wanted to know what we tasted like before committing to dine.

In the distance, I could see the Spires of Sensation—crystalline towers that sang with frequencies that bypassed the ears entirely and spoke directly to the spine. Pilgrims travel to those spires seeking pleasure beyond mortal experience. Most do not return. Those who do rarely speak, except to smile at strange moments.

There were already tens of thousands of beings there.

Not figures in the distance. *Tens of thousands*. Packed into a valley that shouldn't exist, because the Waste doesn't have valleys—you see, it has *absences* where things used to be before Gephorix found them interesting to play with.

And they were not all mortal.

I saw creatures from the Verge—Bloom-touched dancers whose skin sprouted flowers with every step, and Withering pilgrims who seemed to be decomposing in real time yet moved with terrible grace. Entities from the Gloam drifted at the edges—not participating, exactly, but *observing*, their empty forms drinking in the excess of sensation they could no longer feel. I even spotted what I believe was a minor Custodian, its form shifting between masks, perhaps here to report back to the Curator or perhaps—more disturbingly—here for personal reasons.

They'd brought everything: drums made from materials I will refuse to identify before this tribunal, torches that burned in colors the Weave doesn't name, and enough intoxicants to fuel a Tangled Verge metabolic shift.

A man in mismatched armor stumbled past me, grinning with teeth that had been filed to points. "First time?" he asked.

"Yes."

"You'll love it. Or you won't survive it. Both feel the same by hour three." He leaned close enough that I could smell wine and something sweeter on his breath. "The secret is: don't resist. Whatever you feel—pain, pleasure, desire—let it take you. That's the offering. That's what *He* wants."

"Offering?"

The man laughed. "You thought this was just a party? Brother, this is *communion*. Every sensation we give ourselves over to feeds Him. Every dance, every kiss, every wound—they're prayers. The church doesn't advertise, but the faithful know."

He pressed something into my hand—a small vial labeled *ECSTASY (LITERAL)*—and vanished into the crowd before I could refuse.

I still have it. I never opened it. Some knowledge, the Curator teaches, devours the knower.

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The drums started when the last light died.

I have studied rhythm as mathematical principle. I have analyzed the percussive traditions of seventeen cultures across three planes. What I heard that night did not follow rhythm. It *hunted* rhythm. It found the pulse your body wanted to follow and then broke it, repeatedly, until your heartbeat synchronized with something that was not your heart.

People danced.

I do not mean they moved in time. I mean they *danced*—the way a mystic channels spirits, the way a holy woman speaks words of power, the way a sorceress unravels reality. Their bodies became instruments of something vast and indifferent and *hungry* for sensation.

The first death happened seven minutes in.

A young smallfolk, barely into her third decade, simply stopped. Not collapsed. *Stopped*. She remained standing, still moving, but something essential had exited—slipped out through her eyes, perhaps, or evaporated through her pores. Her companions didn't notice for another hour. By then, three more had stopped with her, their bodies keeping something else's time.

No one screamed. The drums were too loud for screaming.

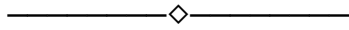
And they did more than dance.

The outer circles of the valley held what the faithful called the *Pleasure Houses*—pavilions of silk and shadow where the congregation explored other forms of worship. Some were elaborate structures, multi-storied and staffed by devoted acolytes of the Many-Masked who had trained their entire lives in the arts of sensation. Others were simple tents where strangers became intimate and intimates became strangers, boundaries dissolving like salt in warm water.

I will not describe what I witnessed there in detail. This is formal testimony.

But I will say this: Gephorig does not distinguish between pleasures. Pain and ecstasy, tenderness and violence, solitary transcendence and the tangle of a dozen bodies moving as one—all of it fed him. All of it was prayer. The Pleasure Houses were temples, and what occurred within them was liturgy as sacred as any hymn.

I saw things that should have horrified me rendered beautiful by context. I saw things that should have been beautiful rendered overwhelming by their *intensity*. I saw beings from three different planes share something I still cannot name, and when they parted, they wept—not from sorrow, but from the knowledge that no experience in their ordinary lives would ever compare.



[NOTE: Spot illustration — A simple tent with warm lantern light amid the dark revelry. The symbol of Ilyra (hearth with three stones) on the tent flap. Contrast: gentle warmth vs. chaotic intensity beyond]

I found refuge near the edge of the valley, where a priestess of Ilyra—yes, *Ilyra*, the Hearthbound, she of comfort and community—had established what she called "The Reprieve".

It was not one tent. It was many throughout the desert.

The largest served as a sanctuary—cool water, actual shade, and the simple miracle of *rest* in a place that punished stillness. Around it, smaller shelters housed the wounded, the overwhelmed, the overstimulated. Priestesses moved between them with practiced calm, offering water, salves, and the most precious commodity at the Dance: someone willing to listen without judgment. Community is their domain, and I am not sure I have ever experienced it quite as intensely as I felt it there.

"You seem surprised," the head priestess said, pressing a bowl of something warm into my hands. Actual soup. Just soup. In the Ashen Waste.

"Your deity doesn't..."

"Belong here?" She laughed—not bitterly, but with the weariness of someone who had answered this question a thousand times. "No. She doesn't. Ilyra's light doesn't reach here—Gephorig's realm rejects her warmth the way oil rejects water. Everything she represents—comfort, community, the gentle hope that tomorrow will be kinder than today—is *anathema* to the Many-Masked. He is intensity. She is reprieve. He demands you feel everything. She asks only that you find comfort after it."

She gestured to the camp around us.

"And yet—here we are. Every Dance. Every thirty-eight and two-thirds years. We set up our tents in the realm of a god who should destroy us on principle, and he *allows* it."

"Why?"

The priestess's smile turned strange. "Because without us, the Dance wouldn't work."

I stared at her.

"Think about it. If there was no reprieve—no water, no rest, no one to catch you when you fall—the congregation would burn out in days. Three days, maybe four. The intensity would consume everyone before the sacrament could build to its crescendo. Gephorig doesn't want a bonfire. He wants a *slow burn*, that eventually erupts. He wants his worshippers to partake for twenty days, not three. And for that, they need somewhere to recover between immolations."

She pressed the bowl more firmly into my hands. "We are the breath between screams. The pause that makes the next sensation *mean* something. Without comfort, intensity loses its contrast. Without hope, despair has no weight. We don't belong here—but balance demands we exist. The Covenant of Balance, the oldest law, the one even gods must answer to: for every extreme, a counterweight."

I looked around the hospitality camp with new eyes. A young woman wept in the arms of a priestess, her body unmarked but something behind her eyes clearly broken. Two men held each other near the water station, shaking, alive. An older woman sat alone, staring at nothing, while a healer gently cleaned wounds she didn't seem to feel. Each of them had touched the limit of sensation and pulled back. Each of them would, in all likelihood, return to the Dance before the portals opened. They were not escaping Gephorix's worship.

They were *acing* it.

"Half these people came because they have nothing left to lose," the priestess continued. "The other half came because they've never lost anything and wanted to know what it felt like. Ilyra doesn't judge any. She doesn't weight the scales. She serves. She comforts. That's the whole of her teaching—that comfort isn't weakness, that community isn't cowardice, that sometimes the most radical act of faith is *not* pursuing the limits of transcendence. She teaches that the simple act of being together, of witnessing each other's survival, is sacred."

She looked out at the dancers in the distance, bodies writhing against the dying light.

"I don't know if Gephorix *respects* us, exactly. But I know he needs us. And that—" she turned back to me with something fierce in her eyes, "—that is a strange kind of victory."

"How many survivors does this tent typically produce?"

"Sixty percent, on a good Dance."

I choked on the soup.

"Oh, that's *excellent* odds. The general survival rate is somewhere around forty-three percent. Better than the seventeenth Congregation—that was one of the total annihilation events. Beautiful, though. They say Gephorix himself manifested to watch the last dancer refuse to stop even as the heat-wraiths took him. Kept dancing until there was nothing left to move with."

She said this the way someone might discuss weather that had been unseasonable but not unreasonable.

"And the other total annihilation?"

"Don't know. No witnesses. That's what 'total' means."

I stayed in Ilyra's camp for three days, watching them work. They asked nothing of those they helped—no conversion, no promises, no compensation. When someone recovered enough to return to the Dance, they let them go without argument. When someone decided to wait for the portals, they provided company without condescension.

This was worship too, I realized. Not the ecstatic surrender to sensation, but the quiet insistence that survival had value. That people mattered even when they chose to throw themselves into the Many-Masked's embrace.

Gephorix and Ilyra, sharing the same desert. Intensity and comfort, existing side by side, neither able to claim the whole truth.

I wondered if that was the real lesson of the Dance.



It continued through nights and days.

I should describe the wonders. There were wonders. An artificer had constructed an instrument that translated starlight directly into sound and memory, and for seventeen hours the Waste sang with frequencies that predated the Covenant of Balance. Three sorcerers collaborated on an illusion so perfect that an entire section of the crowd believed they were dancing in the Tangled Verge—the Bloom incarnate, flowers erupting from their skin, roots threading through their feet. It was beautiful. It was *transcendent*.

Two of the mages did not survive the threefold casting. The third completed the work alone, weeping without pause, her tears falling upward. She was, I learned later, a high priestess of Gephorix—and the illusion was not entertainment. It was liturgy. A sermon in sensory overload, demonstrating that the Many-Masked's domain touched even the realm of wild growth.

A mercenary challenged something to a duel. I did not see what he challenged. Neither did anyone else. He won, apparently, because he returned to the crowd bearing wounds that should have killed him instantly, demanding another drink and insisting it was "just a scratch."

It was not a scratch. I could see his spine. It was smiling at me.

He danced for another two days before whatever was keeping him upright remembered that spines were structural requirements. Someone told me, afterward, that he had been a devoted follower of the Many-Masked for thirty years. That he had come to the Dance specifically seeking the wound that would finally let him experience the boundary between life and death—the ultimate intensity. If so, he found it. Whether he found what lay beyond, I cannot say.

I passed a group returning from the Reprieve—they carried fresh water, dried food, and what appeared to be glowing massage oils.

The tall woman leading them wore robes of deep crimson silk that left little to imagination, cut high at the thigh and open at the back. Gold chains draped from her shoulders to her wrists, and the symbol of the Many-Masked—an endless spiral of overlapping faces—had been burned... *branded* into the skin above her heart. She moved with the easy confidence of someone who had long ago shed any concept of shame. A Priest of this place.

Behind her walked her companions: two men and another woman, each wearing far less. Leather harnesses crossed their bare chests, connected by thin chains to matching collars that bore the same spiral sigil. Their eyes were downcast—not from fear, but from devotion. Pleasure-bound, I realized. Those who had given themselves entirely to their Priestess' will, their service a form of worship as valid as any prayer.

"Nine days left, if we're lucky," the woman said, not looking back at her followers. "The Pleasure Houses on the eastern ridge are supposed to peak around this time. Some say Gephorix himself spends hours there, taking the shapes of all who would give themselves to the houses' ecstasy and euphoria."

"Yes, Lady Velissra," one of the men replied, his voice reverent. "it will be *spectacular*."

She smiled—the smile of a hunter anticipating a feast.

Then she turned and looked at me.

I do not know what she saw. A scholar, probably. Someone who had been watching instead of participating. Someone who clearly needed to be *shown* rather than told. Her smile shifted—no longer anticipatory, but *inviting*. She extended one gold-chained hand toward me, palm up, the gesture unmistakable.

"You," she said. "You look like you need to stop thinking for a while."

I opened my mouth to decline.

What came out was: "I... yes, I suppose I do."

My feet were moving before I understood why. Something about the way she stood, the absolute certainty in her posture, the promise of not having to make decisions for a while—it called to something in me I hadn't known existed. The Pleasure Houses suddenly seemed very reasonable. Collars seemed like an acceptable fashion choice. I found myself wondering what material the chains were made of, and whether they would be cold against my skin.

The Path of Veiled Sight teaches that knowledge without context is dangerous, a voice in my head recited. It sounded like my old instructor, Archivist Mendrel, who had once made me copy the Sixteen Principles of Cognitive Discipline four hundred times for falling asleep during a lecture on epistemological humility.

I stopped walking.

"No," I said, with significantly less conviction than I would have preferred. "No, I am... I am a Chronicler of the Curator Arcanum, and I am here to *observe*, not to—"

"Pity," she said, and she genuinely seemed to mean it. "You would have made a lovely addition."

One of her subordinates looked up at me with what might have been sympathy, or might have been relief that she wouldn't have to share her attention.

They walked back into the realm of intensity without looking back, the chains between them catching the dying light.

I stood there for a long moment, breathing carefully, reciting the Sixteen Principles under my breath until my heartbeat returned to something approaching normal.

In my formal assessment, I have noted that the Ashen Waste poses significant memetic hazards to researchers. This is underselling the problem considerably. I nearly abandoned the Curator, because a woman in silk looked at me with confidence.

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[NOTE: Spot illustration — A sun rising like an open wound. The desert stripped of gentleness. Silhouettes still dancing against the hostile dawn. Ink with bone-gold wash]

The Eighteenth Dawn came.

We had been dancing—or watching, or surviving—for seventeen days. Records show that the Dance typically lasted between seventeen and twenty-one dawns, depending on how long the congregation could sustain its

fervor before the Many-Masked grew bored or satisfied. This year, it seemed, we were approaching the end.

Some dawns in the Ashen Waste do not arrive gently. They *attack*. The temperature, which had been merely unbearable, became actively hostile. The sand, which had been curious, became aggressive. Things that had been hiding during the *allowance* emerged to see what was left.

Mirror scorpions. Pain-worms. Heat-wraiths.

I watched a heat-wraith consume a dancer who refused to stop moving even as the entity enveloped her. She smiled the entire time. The wraith seemed... confused. Perhaps that was the first offering it had ever received willingly.

The crowd, reduced by perhaps thirty percent, did what any sensible group of planar criminals would do.

They kept dancing.

Not because they couldn't stop. Not because they were controlled. Because stopping meant it was over, and being over meant returning to wherever they'd come from, and wherever they'd come from did not have *this*—this intensity, this truth, this feeling of being so completely alive that death became a technicality rather than an ending.

I understand now why Gephorig does not merely *tolerate* the Dance.

He *ordained* it.

The Thirty-Eight-and-Two-Thirds cycle is not arbitrary—it is liturgical. The Many-Masked's most devoted followers have known this for millennia: that the Dance is the highest rite of their faith, a mass communion where tens of thousands, maybe more, offer their sensations to their god simultaneously. Every gasp of pleasure, every cry of pain, every moment of transcendence or terror—all of it flows to him, feeds him, delights him.

We are not guests in his realm. We are not even criminals violating his borders.

We are *congregants*, whether we know it or not.

We are *ingredients* in his ongoing sacrament to discover how much sensation a soul can contain before it either transcends or dissolves.

Both outcomes please him equally. Both are worship.

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The portals reopened.

I estimated the survivors as they filed through. The spirit-speaker who brought me did not return. The priestess of Ilyra stayed behind—not dead, not even wounded, just unwilling to leave when there were still survivors to comfort. I asked one of her acolytes if she would make it.

"She's stayed for every Dance since the twenty-second," the acolyte said. "She always comes back. Eventually. When there's no one left to help."

"How?"

"Ilyra protects those who protect others. Even in places her light can't reach." The acolyte smiled. "That's the thing about compassion. It doesn't need permission to exist. Even here."

"Same time in thirty-eight and two-thirds years?" someone asked the crowd.

There was a cheer. An actual cheer. From the survivors of an event with a sub-fifty-percent survival rate.

I did not cheer.

But I took down the date. I wrote it in the margin of my field journal, in ink that would not fade, in handwriting that was not quite my own.

I stood at the portal for a long moment before finally stepping through to safety.

—— FORMAL TESTIMONY

The Interplanar Travel Network has asked me to provide testimony regarding why this event should remain illegal.

I have no such testimony to offer.

Legality is irrelevant to the Dance. Gephorix does not care about our laws, and neither do those who attend. Making it more illegal will not reduce attendance—it will simply ensure that those who go may not return, and the survival rate will drop further.

I have instead submitted a request to the Curator Arcanum for a formal study of the phenomenon. If beings from across the cosmos—mortal and otherwise—are determined to offer themselves to that intensity, we should at least understand what they receive in exchange.

Some of them find truth.

Some of them find only pain.

Most find both, and cannot tell the difference.

Is that not the Many-Masked's entire theology?

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Addendum, filed six months after original testimony:

The Interplanar Travel Network has formally denied my research request.

I understand their reasoning. The Curator Arcanum exists to ensure knowledge remains humble. What I am proposing is the opposite—to approach a deity of excess and ask what he learns from watching us burn.

But I have kept the vial.

ECSTASY (LITERAL).

It sits on my desk as I write this. The liquid inside catches the light in ways that suggest it knows I am looking.

In thirty-eight and two-thirds years, I will be old. Perhaps too old to survive the Dance.

But the Veiled Sight teaches that some truths should remain hidden—not forever, but until the seeker is ready to pay their cost.

I am not ready.

Though, I suspect, I may be.

The vial catches the light again. Something definitely looking back.

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"Has only resulted in total guest annihilation twice—better than some legal festivals." — Popular saying among those who have attended the Desert Dance

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|| ♦ CURATOR'S NOTE ♦ ||

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This document has been preserved without editorial correction as required by the Path of Open Doors. The Interplanar Travel Network has requested its suppression. The Curator Arcanum has declined, noting that the testimony contains no actionable intelligence and serves primarily as a missive of warning.

Whether it warns away from the Dance or pushes toward it remains, per the Path of Veiled Sight, *deliberately unspecified*.

Knowledge without context is still knowledge. Let the reader determine the lesson.

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